The world in brief

Catch up quickly on the global stories that matter

Photograph: Getty Images

In a televised address, **Donald Trump** said “we are on track to complete all of **America’s** military objectives shortly” in **Iran**. The president vowed to “hit” Iran “extremely hard over the next two to three weeks”. He also repeated his threat to bomb the country’s energy infrastructure should its regime not agree to a deal in the coming weeks.

Mr Trump’s speech did little to soothe **oil prices** or **stockmarkets**. Brent crude, the global oil benchmark, rose while Asian and European indices fell. Mr Trump blamed the “short-term” increase in petrol prices on Iran’s attacks on commercial vessels and suggested that other countries should buy oil from America, as “We have plenty.”

Four astronauts launched into space from Florida, beginning the first voyage around the **Moon** in more than 50 years (they will loop around it in a figure of eight). **NASA’s** Artemis II is the opening mission in a programme designed to return Americans to the lunar surface by 2028, before China does. America ultimately hopes to establish a base there.

Volodymyr Zelensky, **Ukraine’s** president, said he had discussed the possibility of an Easter ceasefire with American negotiators, but

that **Russia** had responded by launching more than 700 drones in an attack on central and western Ukraine. Russia's foreign ministry dismissed Mr Zelensky's proposal as a "PR stunt". Separately, Russia claimed to have taken total control of Ukraine's Luhansk region, which Ukraine denied.

Eight Muslim-majority countries, including Pakistan, Saudi Arabia and Turkey, criticised an **Israeli law** that will expand the use of the **death penalty**, calling it "discriminatory" against Palestinians. The law, which Israel's parliament passed on Monday, makes execution the default punishment for those convicted of deadly terror offences in military courts. Human-rights groups say the sentence will almost exclusively be applied to Palestinians.

The Cook Islands, a sparsely populated string of 15 islets, signed a defence and security agreement with **New Zealand**, its former colonist. The countries had fallen out over the Cook Islands' decision to sign a "comprehensive strategic partnership" deal with China, which New Zealand said caused "significant concern". Under a "free association" agreement, the pair are required to collaborate on security and foreign policy.

SpaceX, Elon Musk's rocket firm, confidentially filed for an initial public offering, potentially one of the largest listings ever. Valued at more than $1trn, SpaceX is reportedly seeking to raise tens of billions of dollars. The company wants to tap public markets to fund its ambitious plans, including missions to Mars and data centres in space.

Figure of the day: 600-800, the typical calorie count of a sticky toffee pudding with custard. Read about why the British favourite is back in vogue.

Photograph: AFP via Getty Images

Trump demands more from America's allies

No country has joined America in battle in Iran apart from Israel, which led the charge. Mr Trump has been scathing about European leaders. In a speech on Wednesday, he called on them to "build up some delayed courage" to secure safe shipping in the Strait of Hormuz. The economic fallout from its closure is now forcing America's allies to act—albeit not how Mr Trump would like.

On Thursday Britain will convene a group of 35 foreign ministers to try to find a way to reopen the Strait of Hormuz after the fighting stops. Mr Trump has suggested he could end the war without a deal to protect the strait, panicking governments reliant on oil and gas from the Gulf. Britain's initiative has been likened to the "coalition of the willing", intended to support Ukraine after a ceasefire. It includes the G7 countries (with the unsurprising exception of America), lots of European ones and some Gulf states, such as Bahrain. "Coalition of the weary" might be more accurate.

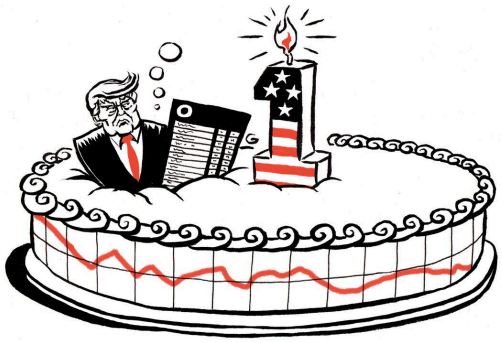


Illustration: David Simons

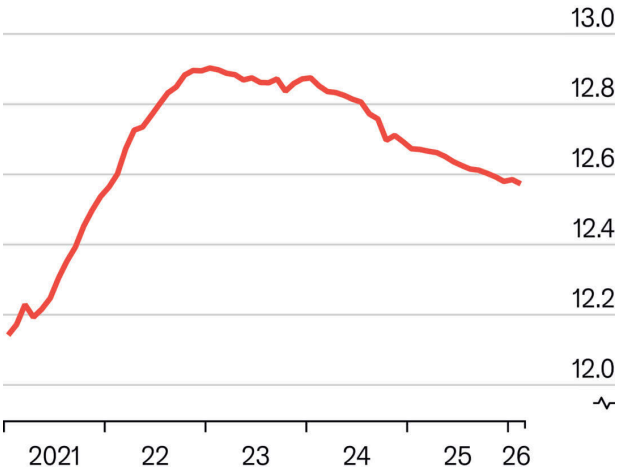
America’s one-eyed merchants

American manufacturers should have done well out of the global trade war Donald Trump unleashed on “Liberation Day” a year ago on Thursday. But even they are at best lukewarm on Mr Trump’s tariffs, which raised levies to the highest level in nearly a century.

Manufacturers bemoan the uncertainty of yo-yoing tariff rates, and the mountain of paperwork that comes with remaining compliant. The sector has shed 100,000 jobs since Mr Trump took office; the rest of the economy has put on 300,000. Another problem is tariffs on inputs, such as raw materials or machines. Many of these are imported, forcing manufacturers to swallow the levy or pass on the costs to customers. Some of the tariffs expire in July. And the next presidential election is not far off; if a Democrat (or a less tariff-prone Republican) succeeds Mr Trump, they could pare the levies back. Pity any manager planning for recruitment or investment.

Spanner in the works

United States, manufacturing employment, m



Source: Bureau of Labour Statistics

Photograph: EPA

The LNG and the short of it

The usually steady stream of tankers reaching Europe's shores from Qatar carrying liquefied natural gas has run dry. QatarEnergy, the state oil and gas giant, normally supplies roughly a fifth of global LNG. But after Iranian drone strikes on its main complex, the company cancelled long-term contracts, including with its four biggest customers: Belgium, China, Italy and South Korea. For Italy, one of Europe's largest gas consumers, Qatar provides around 30% of LNG imports.

The country faces an unprecedented supply shock. Guido Crosetto, the defence minister, said the economic consequences "won't let me sleep". Much damage is now irreversible. Even if the war ended tomorrow, it would be weeks before more gas left the Gulf. QatarEnergy says its facilities may not be repaired for five years. And Europe as a whole will feel the squeeze: stocks had already dwindled to a five-year low before the war, and Asia keeps outbidding it for the remaining gas. More sleepless nights await.

Photograph: Getty Images

Britain’s embattled broadcaster

Tim Davie, the BBC’s outgoing director-general, no doubt hoped for a quiet end to his tenure. Instead, as he departs on Thursday a new scandal has struck the broadcaster. The BBC abruptly sacked Scott Mills, a radio star, reportedly because of allegations that he had a relationship with an underage teenage boy more than 25 years ago. Looming larger still is the issue that forced Mr Davie’s exit: a deceptively edited documentary, which later triggered Donald Trump’s $10bn lawsuit.

Mr Davie’s replacement, Matt Brittin, a former executive at Google, will have to deal with longer-standing challenges. In a polarised world he must keep an audience for a broadcaster with a policy of impartiality. Streaming giants such as Netflix make the BBC’s mandate to appeal to the tastes of an entire nation look antiquated. Mr Brittin is also tasked with protecting the BBC’s voice abroad, where it remains one of the few trusted news sources. Quite the in-tray.

Photograph: Getty Images

A second helping of Wegovy

GLP-1 drugs were originally sold as diabetes medications and have since marched on to become weight-loss drugs. Now Britain's health service will prescribe semaglutide—sold as Wegovy—for cardiovascular prevention. This week NHS England, part of Britain's health service, announced a deal with Novo Nordisk, the drug's Danish manufacturer, to make semaglutide available to 1.2m people who have already suffered a heart attack or stroke.

The case for this is strong. A 2023 study of semaglutide's effectiveness found a 20% relative reduction in major cardiovascular events, with an absolute risk reduction of 1.5%. These benefits appeared before significant weight loss occurred, leading researchers to believe the effect comes from the drug acting directly on the heart and blood vessels, rather than through shedding the kilos.

Wegovy might also be useful for the millions more Britons with cardiovascular disease. Yet, as patients with obesity have already found, a drug can be effective yet unaffordable for the NHS. Expect a slow roll-out.

Illustration: Sandra Navarro

Daily quiz

We will serve you a new question each weekday. On Friday your challenge is to give us all five answers and tell us the theme. Email your responses (and your home city and country) by 1700 GMT on Friday to . We'll pick three winners at random and crown them on Saturday.

Thursday: Which Admiral was selected to be commander of the US Pacific fleet in the wake of the Pearl Harbour attacks?

Wednesday: Who was the only American president to be born in Missouri?

One forges one’s style on the terrible anvil of daily deadlines.

Émile Zola